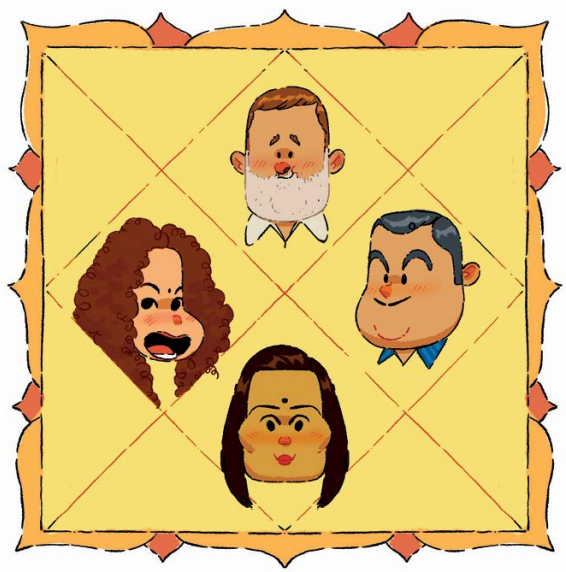
TRIOTS AND EXPATRIATES



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

Brain drain, did you say? Well, some of that effluence can flow back temporarily and become...influence! The BJP, for one, is keenly aware that the deepest nationalist aspiration among some of its core voters in Gujarat is the noble wish to flee the nation altogether. The allure of a life abroad, paradoxically, always seems to get those saffron juices flowing. So, as a desirable role model, there's nothing to beat the figure of the affluent Non-Resident Gujarati (NRG). To mine this patriotic vein, the state BJP has organised a full NRI motorcade—100 cars full of expats flown in specially for this spot of performance propaganda. From Ahmedabad, the swanky caravan crisscrossed through the Patel-dominated villages of central Gujarat's fertile Charotar region—the districts of Anand, Nadiad, Ankleshwar and Bharuch, where every third house has close kin settled abroad. No less than state BJP chieftain (and Navsari candidate) C.R. Patil was on hand to welcome them at journey's end in Surat. But an NRI—or NRG—rally must also play out in its 'native' habitat. So recent weeks saw open-car and bike rallies vroom around in countries like Uganda, South Africa, Canada, US, UK and Australia. Door-to-door and social media campaigns have also been buzzing within NRG circles to keep the faith strong. Pressure groups in their *phoren* homes, celebrity campaigners back in the *gaam*—the BJP has perfected this 'NRGA' employment scheme for a decade.

Kangana Ranaut will get; guess the victors in chosen seats; the worst losers in others; the candidate who'll get the lowest votes all-India; the constituency where NOTA will get voted the most; and the number of seats with a margin of less than 5,000 votes. Interested parties can use horoscopes, numerology, tarot cards, lines on the palm, observation of the movements of animals and birds, any form of mystical knowledge they prefer. Similar dares have gone out during successive polls, but Dr Hamid Dabholkar of MANS says no astrologer or soothsayer has come forth to accept it so far. You can't kill an idea.



▶ MADHYA PRADESH

19-Day U-turn

Vikram Ahake, ex-Kamal Nath aide, had risen to become the first tribal mayor of Madhya Pradesh—in Chhindwara, of course—in 2022. But a classic Congress story that had started with the NSUI was cut short suddenly when he joined the BJP on April 1. Ahake, however, caught his own boomerang with a gharwapsi on polling day, April 19. Despite a video statement professing loyalty to Nath Sr and his MP son Nakul, and talking of feeling 'suffocated' in the BJP, insiders suggest a mix of emotions and pragmatism. The mayoral chair is still at stake. So, picture *abhi baaki hai*.